

SC301 Habermas and the Public Sphere

Context

-Marx on ideology – Early Marx (ruling class, mental means of production, base and superstructure)
-Frankfurt school – Adorno and Horkheimer, dialectic of enlightenment, culture, culture industry, standardisation, pseudo-individualization, catharsis. Sceptical on revolution, state-capitalism / fascism, reduces role of agency (perhaps some in the Bad Infinity, avant-garde)
BUT Walter Benjamin art and mechanical reproduction, Art having cult and exhibition value, mass production gives possibility of different perceptions, new means of production so possible agency within culture.
AND Jurgen Habermas – public sphere as possible sphere for democratisation

Jurgen Habermas (1929-)

Habermas' account of the public sphere can be understood as a two-part narrative: the emergence of a liberal bourgeois public sphere; and its eventual refeudalisation by the state and commercial private interests. The idea of the public sphere can be understood as a public forum for rational and critical debate. Whilst such forums date from Classical Greece, they assumed a new and distinctive form in the 17th and 18th centuries, particularly in Britain where there occurred a rapidly developing capitalist economy, a reconstituted public state, and the establishment of a bourgeois civil society.

It's between this newly reconstituted realm of public authority and the private realm of civil society that there emerges a new sphere of the public, a space in which a body of private persons can assemble to discuss matters of public concern or common interest. In particular, the public sphere created a forum in which the authority of the state could be criticized and called upon to justify itself before an informed and reasoning public.

Public life was now a theatre in which the authorities (the monarch, aristocracy and church) occasionally displayed their power on ceremonial occasions.

“By the public sphere we mean first of all a realm of our social life in which something approaching public opinion can be formed. Access is guaranteed to all citizens. A portion of the public sphere comes into

being in every conversation in which private individuals assemble to form a public body. In a large public body, this kind of communication requires specific means for transmitting information and influencing those who receive it. Today, newspapers and magazines, radio and television are the media of the public sphere.”

The Ideal Speech Situation

Anybody with the competence to speak be allowed to take part in a discussion

Anyone is allowed to question any assertion whatsoever in that discussion.

Anyone is allowed to introduce any assertion whatever into that discussion.

No person be prevented from exercising their rights to freedom of expression.

That the consensus of opinion be decided by the most rational argument.

Some Criticisms

1. Although the public sphere was based on the principle of universal access, in practice it was premised on significant structural exclusions
2. Habermas places too much emphasis on the bourgeois public sphere, ignoring the significance of other forms of public discourse and popular social movements.
3. There are problems with Habermas’ argument concerning the decline of the public sphere and the concept of refeudalisation, is this just part of the continuation of capitalism
4. Habermas tends to treat the recipients of media messages as passive consumers unless they have access to the Public Sphere

Fraser’s critique of the public sphere

Fraser, N. (1999) ‘Rethinking the Public Sphere: A Contribution to the Critique of Actually Existing Democracy’, During, S. (Ed.), *The Cultural Studies Reader*, London: Routledge, pp518-536.

Nancy Fraser’s critique of the public sphere represents one of the most influential feminist and critical interventions into democratic theory in the late twentieth century. Writing in *Rethinking the Public Sphere: A Contribution to the Critique of Actually Existing Democracy* (1999), Fraser challenges the dominant Habermasian model of the public

sphere, arguing that it is both **empirically inaccurate** and **normatively exclusionary**. Her intervention is **not a rejection of the public sphere as such, but rather a reconstruction of it—one that accounts for power, inequality, and social difference within “actually existing” democracies**. In doing so, Fraser offers a more **pluralistic and conflict-aware** understanding of public discourse and democratic participation.

Fraser’s critique is directed primarily at Jürgen Habermas’s classical formulation of the bourgeois public sphere, which **presents it as a space of rational-critical debate among private individuals, oriented toward the common good and free from domination**. While Habermas acknowledged that this ideal was historically limited, Fraser argues that his model nevertheless continues to function as a normative benchmark that obscures systemic exclusions. According to Fraser, the **bourgeois public sphere was never as inclusive, egalitarian, or disinterested as it claimed to be. Women, the working class, racialised minorities, and other subordinated groups were structurally excluded, not accidentally marginalised**. Thus, the supposed universality of the public sphere was built upon social inequalities that were bracketed rather than eliminated.

A central component of Fraser’s critique **concerns the assumption that social inequalities can be “bracketed” in public deliberation**. Habermas suggests that participants can set aside differences in status and power in order to deliberate as equals. **Fraser rejects this as unrealistic and ideologically naïve. She argues that inequalities rooted in class, gender, race, and sexuality inevitably shape who can speak, who is heard, and whose arguments are taken seriously. Discursive norms that privilege particular styles of speech—such as calm rationality, abstraction, and dispassion—often function to disadvantage subordinated groups whose communicative practices may differ**. As a result, formally open public spheres can still reproduce domination through informal mechanisms of exclusion.

Fraser also challenges the idea of a singular, unified public sphere. The Habermasian model assumes that the public sphere should be one comprehensive arena in which citizens deliberate together. Fraser argues instead that this ideal suppresses difference and benefits dominant groups. In stratified societies, **a single public sphere tends to reflect the perspectives and interests of those already in power, while marginalising countervailing viewpoints**. For Fraser, **plurality is not a democratic deficit but a democratic necessity**. The

expectation that all participants converge in one space on shared norms of discourse risks silencing oppositional voices rather than integrating them.

In place of a singular public sphere, Fraser introduces the concept of **subaltern counterpublics**. These are alternative discursive arenas formed by members of subordinated social groups in which they can develop oppositional interpretations of their identities, interests, and needs. Examples include **feminist publics, Black publics, and queer publics**. Counterpublics serve a dual function: they provide spaces of **withdrawal and regroupment, and they act as bases for agitation directed toward wider publics**. Rather than being inherently separatist or anti-democratic, **counterpublics are, for Fraser, essential to participatory parity in conditions of structural inequality**.

Another major aspect of Fraser's critique concerns the **distinction between public and private**. The classical bourgeois public sphere relied on a sharp separation between public matters of common concern and private matters of **family, sexuality, and domestic life**. **Fraser argues that this division has historically functioned to depoliticise issues that disproportionately affect women and other subordinated groups. By defining matters such as domestic violence, reproductive rights, and care work as "private," dominant publics excluded them from legitimate political debate**. Fraser insists that **what counts as a matter of public concern is itself a political question**, not a neutral or pre-given boundary.

Fraser further critiques the assumption that the public sphere should be oriented exclusively toward the common good rather than particular interests. She argues that this distinction is misleading, since **claims presented as universal often mask the particular interests of dominant groups**. Subordinated groups, by contrast, are frequently criticised for being "self-interested" when they articulate their needs. **Fraser contends that democratic legitimacy does not require the elimination of interests but rather fair conditions under which competing interests can be articulated and contested**. Democratic deliberation should therefore be understood as inherently conflictual, not consensual.